



Extending Situational Strength Theory to Account for Situation-Outcome Mismatch

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Abstract

The current paper was motivated by previous results (Meyer et al. *Journal of Management*, 40, 1010–1041, 2014) that appeared to contradict the popular idea that “strong” situations *weaken* the impact of personality on job performance. We extend situational strength theory by contending that, when a strong situation blocks one outlet for poor performance (e.g., low task performance), employees predisposed toward such behavior experience negative affect. They then displace their negative behavior to a second outlet (e.g., counterproductive work behavior), thereby *strengthening* their predispositions, unless that second outlet, too, is blocked by a strong situation. We then test this assertion using a two-wave survey ($N = 369$), analyzed using dual-stage moderated mediation. Results indicate strong support for this assertion vis-à-vis the personality traits of conscientiousness and agreeableness, thereby replicating and extending Meyer et al.’s (*Journal of Management*, 40, 1010–1041, 2014) seemingly anomalous results. However, results indicate weaker support vis-à-vis a third personality trait, emotional stability, which has a weaker bivariate relationship with counterproductive work behavior. The extended situational strength theory suggests important avenues for future research as well as practical guidelines for avoiding unintended consequences when applying strong situations in organizations.

Keywords Situational strength · Strong situation · Weak situation · Unintended consequences · Replication · Moderated mediation · Counterproductive work behavior · Personality · Reactance · Displacement

The inspiration for this paper was a set of findings (Meyer et al., 2014) that appeared to be anomalous to situational strength theory (Meyer, Dalal, & Hermida, 2010; Mischel, 1968). We simultaneously examine situational strength pertaining to two performance-related outcomes: task performance and counterproductive work behavior. By so doing, the paper extends

conventional situational strength theory by positing that the primary situational strength prediction holds only in conditions when situational strength cues match the outcome domain. According to the extended theory, Meyer et al.’s (2014) purportedly anomalous findings are in fact to be expected—and are due to behavioral displacement associated with a situation-outcome mismatch.

Reeshad S. Dalal and Balca Alaybek contributed equally to this work. The order of these two authors’ names is arbitrary.

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In the next section of the paper, we briefly discuss situational strength theory, its application to organizational settings, and the purportedly anomalous findings that motivated the current paper. Subsequently, we extend the theory so as to explain not only cases where the situation matches the performance outcome of interest but also cases where it does not.

Situational Strength: Primary Prediction, Supportive Findings, and Recent Anomalous Findings

Situational strength pertains to the presence of implicit or explicit cues provided by external entities regarding the desirability of potential behaviors in a particular situation (Meyer et al., 2010). In strong situations, people interpret situations similarly and possess similar beliefs regarding (in)appropriate behavioral responses. In other words, the theory predicts that people's behavior is driven by the situation in strong situations and by personality in weak situations. For example, a red traffic light represents a strong situation in which the only appropriate behavior is to stop one's vehicle; in contrast, a yellow traffic light is a weak situation in which some drivers may stop whereas others may attempt to speed through the intersection before the light turns red (Cooper & Withey, 2009; Mischel, 1977). As another example, an organizational dress code represents a strong situation in which the only appropriate behavior is adherence to the dress code; conversely, a "Casual Fridays" policy represents a weaker situation in which employees' outfits are likely to represent their individual preferences.

Considerable empirical support for this primary situational strength prediction has accumulated in the organizational literature. Several meta-analyses have been conducted at the level of the *occupation*, distinguishing between strong and weak occupations. For example, Meyer, Dalal, and Bonaccio (2009) operationalized situational strength as occupation-level constraints and consequences. These authors demonstrated meta-analytically that the personality trait of conscientiousness predicted both task performance and overall job performance more strongly in occupations low in constraints and consequences (e.g., poets, lyricists, and creative writers) than in occupations high in constraints and consequences (e.g., nuclear equipment operation technicians). Bowling, Khazon, Meyer, and Burrus (2015) used a meta-analytic approach very similar to Meyer et al.'s (2009) and reached relatively similar conclusions despite focusing on job satisfaction rather than conscientiousness as a predictor of performance. Judge and Zapata (2015) also used a meta-analytic approach relatively similar to Meyer et al.'s (2009), though their operationalizations of occupation-level situational strength differed slightly. These authors demonstrated that the incorporation of a situational

strength perspective increased validity and economic utility for most of the Big Five personality traits.

Several primary studies have also provided supportive evidence. For example, at the level of the *organization*, Lee and Dalal (2016) operationalized situational strength as organizational climate strength. They demonstrated that conscientiousness predicted safety compliance behavior and safety helping behavior more strongly in organizations that were low rather than high in safety climate strength. Other primary studies have been conducted at the level of the *job*. Barrick and Mount (1993) operationalized situational strength as low autonomy. These authors demonstrated that the personality traits of conscientiousness and extraversion predicted job performance more strongly for managers whose jobs were high rather than low in autonomy. Similarly, Meyer et al. (2014) made use of previous theoretical work (Meyer et al., 2010) to operationalize situational strength as the clarity and consistency of information received as well as the constraints on and consequences of decision and action. These authors found that conscientiousness and agreeableness were related more strongly with organizational citizenship behavior for employees who worked in weak rather than strong job situations.

The Meyer et al. (2014) study is also notable, however, because it revealed anomalous findings with regard to a different outcome: counterproductive work behavior. Job-related situational strength did interact with personality traits in predicting counterproductive work behavior. Contrary to the authors' prediction, however, strong situations enhanced rather than attenuated the impact of personality on counterproductive work behavior.

In the current paper, we aim to replicate these purportedly anomalous results. More importantly, we propose an extended version of situational strength theory that predicts precisely these results.

Extending Situational Strength Theory

The current paper extends situational strength theory by: (1) incorporating the need for situational strength cues to match the outcome domain of interest (i.e., performance criterion), and (2) discussing relationship patterns associated with a situation-outcome mismatch. The full conceptual model, which examines the combined effects of a mismatch and a match, is provided in Fig. 1.

Situation-Outcome Match Conceptualizations of situational strength in organizational settings (e.g., Meyer et al., 2014) assess the presence of informational cues, from which employees learn that low levels of job performance are inappropriate. Yet, these conceptualizations mostly involve one specific job performance outcome: task performance. Task performance is employee behavior that contributes directly to the

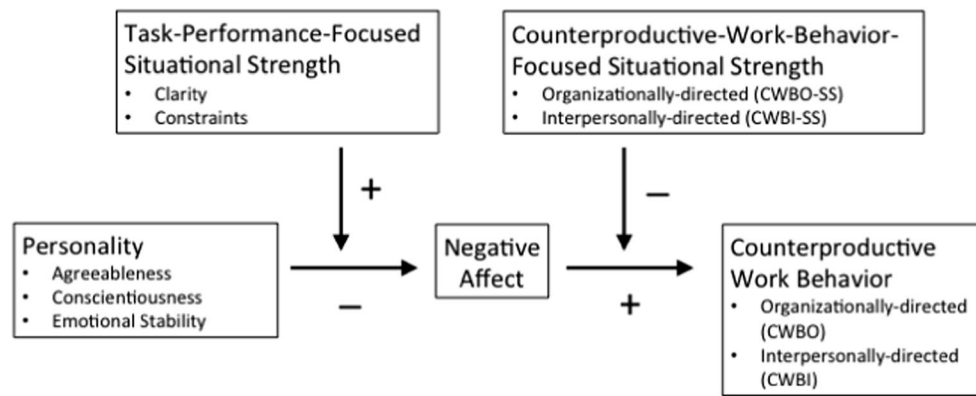


Fig. 1 Full conceptual model (i.e., first- and second-stage dual moderated mediation model) tested in hypothesis 4

organization's technical core and that is recognized in organizational reward systems (Borman & Motowidlo, 1997). In situations that are strong with regard to task performance, personality should exhibit less impact on task performance. However, situations that are strong with regard to task performance should not be expected to exert the same effects on *other* forms of job performance.

Instead, situational strength should be assessed separately for each major domain of job performance. Or, to be more precise, a particular domain of job performance is more likely to need its own conceptualization of situational strength to the extent that this domain can be distinguished from task performance. Perhaps for this reason, Meyer et al.'s (2014) predictions were supported in the case of organizational citizenship behavior but not in the case of counterproductive work behavior.

Organizational citizenship behavior is intentional employee behavior that is more discretionary and less frequently recognized and rewarded than task performance, but that nonetheless improves the functioning of the organization (Dalal, 2005). Like task performance, organizational citizenship behavior is a major domain of job performance (Dalal, Lam, Weiss, Welch, & Hulin, 2009; Rotundo & Sackett, 2002). Conceptually, however, organizational citizenship behavior is quite closely related to task performance. For example, organizational citizenship behavior includes behavior such as volunteering for additional task assignments, helping co-workers with their tasks, and going above and beyond expectations associated with task behavior (Fox, Spector, Goh, Bruursema, & Kessler, 2011). This may explain why Meyer et al.'s (2014) conceptualization of situational strength, although focused on task performance, "worked" with regard to organizational citizenship behavior as well. Specifically, as predicted, Meyer et al. found that the impact of personality on organizational citizenship behavior was stronger in weak than in strong task-performance-focused situations.

Counterproductive work behavior (hereafter, CWB), the third major domain of job performance, is intentional employee behavior that is harmful to an organization's legitimate

interests (Dalal, 2005; Sackett, 2002). Conceptually, CWB is not strongly negatively related to task performance. For instance, it is possible for an employee to steal from the cash register and to criticize the organization to outsiders while nonetheless achieving a high quantity and quality of task performance. CWB is therefore likely to require its own conceptualization of situational strength.

Our conceptualization of CWB-focused situational strength builds on the existing research on employee perceptions associated with various forms of CWB (viz., aggression, bullying, incivility, and sexual harassment; Hulin, Fitzgerald, & Drasgow, 1996; Yang, Caughlin, Gazica, Truxillo, & Spector, 2014). We define CWB-focused situational strength as *employee perceptions regarding the organization's extent of intolerance (vs. tolerance) of CWB*. Employees may form such perceptions based on their own experience or their observation of other employees. Alternately, employees may form such perceptions based on relevant information provided by organizational authorities (Dalal, Bashshur, & Credé, 2011).

When predicting CWB, using a CWB-focused conceptualization of situational strength provides a match between situational strength cues and the outcome domain of interest. In weak CWB-focused situations, employees would receive ambiguous messages, mixed messages, or few messages at all regarding the organization's level of tolerance for CWB. Thus, employees are likely to conclude that the organization is relatively tolerant of CWB. Conversely, in strong CWB-focused situations, employees would receive clear and consistent information that the organization is intolerant of CWB, would realize that severe negative consequences are likely to follow their enactment of CWB, and would conclude that their freedom to engage in CWB is severely constrained.

Under circumstances of a match between the outcome (CWB) and the situational cues (CWB-focused situational strength), therefore, the primary prediction from conventional situational strength theory should hold. Employees in organizations that are intolerant of CWB (i.e., strong CWB-focused situation) should refrain from engaging in CWB. In contrast,

employees in organizations less intolerant of CWB (i.e., weak CWB-focused situation) should engage in levels of CWB consistent with their own dispositional tendencies. More formally:

Hypothesis 1: *The impact of personality traits on counterproductive work behavior is moderated—specifically, weakened—by counterproductive-work-behavior-focused situational strength.*

Implicit in the discussion preceding hypothesis 1 is that we additionally do *not* expect the impact of personality traits on CWB to be attenuated in a strong *task-performance-focused* situation. This leads to two possibilities. The first possibility is a null hypothesis: task-performance-focused situational strength is essentially irrelevant to the impact of personality traits on CWB. The second possibility is that the impact of personality traits on CWB will actually be enhanced in a strong task-performance-focused situation—in other words, the ostensibly anomalous pattern of results observed by Meyer et al. (2014). Next, we explain why we favor this second possibility.

Situation-Outcome Mismatch We propose that the ostensibly anomalous results observed by Meyer et al. (2014) actually reflect a substitution or displacement from one form of poor performance to another. Specifically, we propose that, after employees find that low task performance is blocked by a strong situation, they engage in CWB as a substitute. Evidence for behavioral substitution or displacement comes from the research literatures on two forms of work behavior relevant to CWB: employee withdrawal and displaced aggression. We discuss relevant research on withdrawal and displaced aggression in turn, and we then apply this research to the present study.

Researchers have long been interested in the relationships between various forms of withdrawal behavior—primarily lateness, absenteeism, and turnover (the first two of which are also forms of CWB). According to the “compensatory forms” model (Hulin, 1991; Rosse & Miller, 1984), different forms of withdrawal may serve the same psychological function: namely, avoiding an aversive work situation. Withdrawal serves as a “relief valve” (Rosse & Miller, 1984, p. 204), helping the employee avoid the aversive work situation and thereby reduce negative affect. However, if one form of withdrawal (e.g., absenteeism) is effectively blocked due to organizational policies—that is, if there exists a strong situation specific to one form of withdrawal—then employees will compensate by enacting other forms of withdrawal (e.g., lateness) that alleviate the experienced negative affect.

Workplace aggression (Hershcovis et al., 2007) is a construct operationalized in a manner very similar to CWB. However, research on aggression additionally incorporates the idea of displaced aggression, which has not been a focus in CWB research. The displaced aggression literature

(Marcus-Newhall, Pedersen, Carlson, & Miller, 2000; Miller, 1941) builds on the frustration-aggression hypothesis (Berkowitz, 1989) by noting that retaliating directly against the source of the frustration can often be costly to the person. Stated differently (using situational strength terminology), a strong situation may exist that discourages retaliation against the source of the frustration. In such cases, the displaced aggression literature suggests that people relieve frustration by displacing their aggression toward another target that serves a similar psychological function as the original source of the frustration.

Applied to the current study, behavioral substitution or displacement is likely to work as follows. Certain employees (e.g., unconscientious employees) are predisposed to lower levels of job performance. These employees may encounter a strong situation conveying the idea that low levels of task performance are unacceptable. A strong task-performance-focused situation has the *intended* effect of making all employees, including those predisposed to low performance, enact moderate-to-high levels of task performance. Yet, a strong task-performance-focused situation also has the *unintended* effect of letting employees predisposed to low performance displace that predisposition to other (mismatched) forms of low performance, such as CWB. Such employees would in any case have been predisposed to higher levels of CWB, but that tendency is now exacerbated by the fact that another primary “outlet” for their low-performance predisposition has been blocked. Rather than weakening the impact of personality traits on CWB, task-performance-focused situational strength should strengthen it.

Although this pattern of results is not what Meyer et al. (2014) expected, it is what they found. We therefore expect to replicate Meyer et al.’s (2014) findings. Specifically, we predict:

Hypothesis 2: *The impact of personality traits on counterproductive work behavior is moderated—specifically, strengthened—by task-performance-focused situational strength.*

The question then arises as to the *process* by which task-performance-focused situational strength enhances the impact of personality traits on CWB. As alluded to previously, negative affect is implicated in both the “compensatory forms” of withdrawal model and the displaced aggression process. A third body of research also invokes negative affect: the theory of reactance suggests that eliminating a person’s autonomy to engage in a particular behavior leads to a psychological state of reactance that energizes the person to restore behavioral autonomy (Brehm, 2000). Reactance has been conceptualized in multiple ways, but the experience of negative emotions appears central to most conceptualizations (Miron & Brehm, 2006). In terms of specific negative emotions, anger is often but not always instigated in reactance situations; moreover, other discrete negative emotions are sometimes instigated in

reactance situations (Miron & Brehm, 2006). Reactance therefore appears to be best conceptualized as a broad negative affect construct rather than a narrow anger construct.

Various theoretical frameworks therefore converge on the idea that blocking an outlet for goal achievement results in negative affect, which in turn leads to a greater propensity to use a substitute outlet for goal achievement. Applied to the present context, an employee who is predisposed to low performance, but who is blocked from engaging in low task performance, is likely to experience negative affect and in turn to engage in more CWB than usual. To summarize, we expect the following first-stage moderated mediation model:

Hypothesis 3: *The moderating (specifically, strengthening) effect of task-performance-focused situational strength on the relationship between personality traits and counterproductive work behavior is itself mediated by negative affect.*

Finally, consider a dispositional tendency whose behavioral expression is strengthened by a mismatch between the outcome and one aspect of the situation. The behavioral expression of this dispositional tendency can simultaneously be weakened by a match between the outcome and another aspect of the situation. As discussed previously, situational strength can take more than one form: for instance, task-performance-focused and CWB-focused. The full conceptual model we examine—see Fig. 1—juxtaposes both forms of situational strength, with the former being mismatched and the latter matched with the outcome of interest: CWB.

As suggested by Fig. 1, the extended version of situational strength theory (when applied specifically to task performance and CWB) can be summarized as follows. Employees who are dispositionally inclined to low performance will experience enhanced negative affect when the outlet of low task performance is blocked via a strong task-performance-focused situation. As a result, they will engage in more CWB than usual unless there *also* exists a strong CWB-focused situation. Therefore, although each type of strong situation serves as a hurdle that inhibits low performance of the form specifically targeted by the situation, each type of strong situation also serves as a ladder that facilitates other forms of low performance. In other words, imposing a strong situation will backfire when there is a mismatch between the situational cues and the performance domains of interest. More generally, imposing a strong situation will backfire when situational-strength-relevant cues do not simultaneously cover *all* the performance domains of interest. In sum, we expect the following dual-stage moderated mediation model to hold:

Hypothesis 4: *The moderated mediation model proposed in Hypothesis 3 is further qualified, such that the second stage of the mediation—namely, the relationship between negative affect and counterproductive work behavior—is moderated (specifically, weakened) by counterproductive-work-behavior-focused situational strength.*

Method

Participants and Procedures

The data for the current study were obtained as part of a large-scale investigation on situational strength. Participants were required to be at least 18 years of age, reside in the USA or India (the two countries in which payment via [Amazon.com](https://www.amazon.com) is most convenient), work at least 20 h/week, work in an organization with at least 50 employees, and work in an organization that whose hierarchy includes at least two levels of management above the participant's level. These last two inclusion criteria were not particularly relevant to the current study, but were instead relevant to an additional research project for which these data were also collected.

Participants were recruited through [Amazon.com](https://www.amazon.com)'s Mechanical Turk (MTurk). MTurk is increasingly being used by management researchers as an online labor market to recruit participants (Giacopelli, Simpson, Dalal, Randolph, & Holland, 2013; Shah, Cross, & Levin, 2018). Research has also shown that data collected via MTurk participants are at least as reliable and valid as data obtained through traditional research methods (e.g., Buhrmester, Kwang, & Gosling, 2011; Hauser & Schwarz, 2015; Holden, Dennie, & Hicks, 2013; Kees, Berry, Burton, & Sheehan, 2017; Paolacci, Chandler, & Ipeirotis, 2010; see also Walter, Seibert, Goering, & O'Boyle, 2019).

We collected survey data in two waves, separated by 2 weeks. We chose a 2-week interval between the two timepoints because researchers have argued that such an interval is neither too long for a potential change in status to occur nor too short for carry-over effects to be observed (Marx, Menezes, Horovitz, Jones, & Warren, 2003). Consequently, in management research, a two-week interval is frequently used in longitudinal survey designs (e.g., Chen, Ployhart, Thomas, Anderson, & Bliese, 2011; Hideg & Ferris, 2017). We measured demographic variables and personality traits (i.e., conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability) at time 1. We measured CWB-focused situational strength, negative affect, and CWB at time 2. We measured task-performance-focused situational strength (clarity and constraints) at both time 1 and time 2. The time 1 measurement of task-performance-focused situational strength provides a better representation of the temporal order suggested in the overall conceptual model (see Fig. 1), whereas the time 2 measurement permits a cleaner comparison with CWB-focused situational strength (which was measured at time 2). Overall, however, as will be discussed subsequently, results for task-performance-focused situational strength were largely similar across the two measurement waves—thereby attesting to the robustness of the findings.

As suggested by Cheung, Burns, Sinclair, and Sliter (2017), we took a sequence of steps to address the potential methodological concerns and threats to validity associated with MTurk data collection. Specifically, clarity and constraints items were

grouped into separate survey pages, the order of which was randomized so as to prevent order effects. Moreover, separating the measures of predictors and criteria temporally (by collecting data in two waves) is a methodological remedy intended to reduce common-method bias in the case of a single rater (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003).

As another check on data quality, we did not simply assume that putative participants would adhere to stated inclusion criteria. Rather, we used a brief prescreening survey during which we asked questions on topics related to each of the inclusion criteria. Individuals whose responses did not adhere to the inclusion criteria were informed that they were ineligible to participate in the study. In addition, we repeated this set of questions at the end of the time 1 survey to assess consistency of responses. We found that 16 individuals (3.4% of the time 1 sample) whose initial set of responses permitted them to participate in the study subsequently (i.e., at the end of the time 1 survey) provided one or more responses that would have rendered them ineligible for participation. We excluded these individuals' data prior to determining the effective time 1 sample size. Moreover, because the survey was conducted in the English language, we excluded data from a further three individuals who indicated that they were not fluent in English.

We furthermore examined the data for inattentive responding (Huang, Curran, Keeney, Poposki, & DeShon, 2012; Johnson, 2005). Specifically, we screened for respondents who missed 50% or more data on any focal variable and/or who included the same response to all the personality items (the latter would indicate inattentive responding because the measure included reverse-coded items). There were no such cases. Finally, we screened for cases with completion times more than 2 standard deviations below or above the mean. There were no cases with completion times more than 2 standard deviations below the mean. There were five cases with completion times more than 2 standard deviations above the mean. We ran the analyses twice, once with and once without these five cases. Because substantive conclusions were identical, we report the results that include these five cases.

The effective time 1 sample size was therefore 448. The time 2 sample size was 369, indicating an 81.8% retention rate across time points. A series of *t* tests comparing the participants who completed both time 1 and time 2 surveys versus those who completed only time 1 surveys in terms of demographics (i.e., age, country of residence, and gender) and the time 1 focal variables (i.e., agreeableness, conscientiousness, emotional stability, clarity, and constraints) revealed nonsignificant differences except for mean scores on constraints, conscientiousness, and emotional stability. Specifically, the subgroup who completed only time 1 reported experiencing a higher level of constraints ($t(446) = 3.00, p < .01$, Cohen's $d = 0.36$), reported possessing a lower level of conscientiousness ($t(446) = -2.17, p < .05$, Cohen's $d = 0.27$), and reported possessing a higher level of emotional stability ($t(446) = 2.79, p < .01$, Cohen's $d = 0.35$).

Of the 369 participants in the final sample, 54% were US employees and 46% were Indian employees. In terms of job category, most participants were professionals (41%), followed by managers (18%), clerical or office workers (13%), and technicians (11%). In terms of demographic characteristics, 30% were female and the mean age of the sample was 33 years ($SD = 9.30$ years). We controlled statistically for gender and age in the focal analyses because the sample was predominantly male and relatively young and because gender and age have been shown to relate meta-analytically both to personality (Costa, Terracciano, & McCrae, 2001) and to CWB (Berry, Ones, & Sackett, 2007).

Measures

Personality Three personality traits—agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability—were measured. We chose agreeableness and conscientiousness for two reasons. First, the current study aimed to replicate Meyer et al.'s (2014) “anomalous” results (and to provide an extension of situational strength theory that accounts for these results)—and Meyer et al. focused only on agreeableness and conscientiousness. Second, agreeableness and conscientiousness were the two traits appreciably related to CWB in Berry et al.'s (2007) meta-analysis. Specifically, in the Berry et al. meta-analysis, these traits were the only two for which the corrected meta-analytic correlations with organizationally directed CWB, interpersonally directed CWB, or both exceeded 0.30—and could therefore be characterized as “medium” (vs. “small”) effect sizes, according to Cohen's (1992) rules of thumb.

Appreciable “baseline” (i.e., without considering situational strength) personality-CWB correlations—determined via Berry et al.'s (2007) meta-analytic results—are important to consider. This is because both the stronger and weaker personality-CWB correlations expected under situational strength theory are expected to be in the same direction: for instance, negative in the case of the conscientiousness-CWB relationship. In other words, one would not expect a cross-over interaction in which the direction of the personality-performance relationship actually flips in a strong situation, compared to a weak situation. That is to say, the situational strength idea is not that personality predicts performance in the opposite direction in a strong situation, but rather that personality fails to predict performance appreciably in a strong situation. This means that, when selecting personality traits for inclusion, one should select only those traits that actually have an appreciable baseline personality-CWB relationship, such that the relationship has the potential to be significantly weakened (in a strong situation) without tipping over into an opposite-direction relationship.

Conversely, however, a case could be made for including emotional stability as an additional predictor, even though it exhibits a somewhat weaker baseline relationship with CWB.

In particular, including emotional stability would be consistent with research on “integrity” (Marcus, Höft, & Riediger, 2006). Such research, which views integrity as a dispositional basis for avoiding CWB, generally conceptualizes integrity as a compound trait consisting primarily of conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability—seemingly in that order (i.e., Marcus et al., 2006 suggested that integrity is likely to be composed of four of the six facets of conscientiousness, three of the six facets of agreeableness, two of the six of emotional stability, and one of the six of extraversion; see also Catano, O’Keefe, Francis, & Owens, 2018). We therefore decided to include emotional stability in our study as well.

The three personality traits were measured using John, Donahue, and Kentle’s (1991) Big Five Inventory (BFI). Agreeableness and conscientiousness were each measured via nine items, and emotional stability was measured via eight items, using a 5-point scale (1 = “disagree strongly,” 5 = “agree strongly”). A sample item for agreeableness is: “Is considerate and kind to almost everyone.” A sample item for conscientiousness is: “Does a thorough job.” A sample item for emotional stability is: “Is emotionally stable, not easily upset.”

Negative Affect We measured negative affect via the Positive and Negative Affect Schedule (PANAS; Watson & Clark, 1999). Participants indicated the extent to which they experienced ten discrete negative emotion items (e.g., “hostile,” “distressed,” “upset,” “jittery”) in the past week, using a 5-point scale (1 = “very slightly or not at all,” 5 = “extremely”).

Organizationally Directed CWB and Interpersonally Directed CWB Both organizationally directed CWB (CWBO) and interpersonally directed CWB (CWBI) were measured with Bennett and Robinson’s (2000) workplace deviance measure. Meta-analytic results (Berry, Carpenter, & Barratt, 2012) have demonstrated that mean levels of reported CWB were higher when self-reports rather than other reports of CWB were used. This suggests that socially desirable responding under self-reports, though a concern, may be less problematic than the covert nature of many forms of CWB and consequently the limited opportunity on the part of supervisors and even coworkers to observe such behavior (Dalal, 2005). Berry et al.’s meta-analysis further demonstrated that relationships with other variables were generally stronger when self-reports rather than other reports of CWB were used. Consequently, we used self-reports of CWB. Our use of self-reports of CWB, and indeed Bennett and Robinson’s (2000) measure, was also consistent with Meyer et al.’s (2014) study whose results we sought to replicate (and extend). A sample CWBO item was “Taken property from work without permission.” A sample CWBI item was “Made an ethnic, religious, or racial remark or joke at work”. CWBO was measured with 12 items, and CWBI was measured with 7 items. All items were measured on a 7-point scale (1 = “never,” 7 = “daily”).

CWB-Focused Situational Strength We measured CWB-focused situational strength by modifying the response anchors and prompts of the aforementioned measure of CWB. Participants were asked to respond to the question “To what extent does your organization discourage or encourage the following behaviors?” on the same 19 CWB items as above. Paralleling the measure of CWB, CWBO-focused situational strength was measured with 12 items and CWBI-focused situational strength with 7 items. A 7-point scale was used (1 = “very strongly discourages,” 7 = “very strongly encourages”).¹ All items were reverse coded prior to data analysis, so that higher scores indicate higher levels of CWB-focused situational strength.

Task-Performance-Focused Situational Strength We measured task-performance-focused situational strength using an adapted version of Meyer et al.’s (2014) situational strength at work (SSW) scale. For reasons described below, we could not include all four of Meyer et al.’s (2010, 2014) facets of situational strength. We therefore included one “positive” and one “negative” facets of situational strength (see José et al., 2011). A positive facet of situational strength is one that relates positively to job attitudes (e.g., job satisfaction and organizational commitment) and one for which an inadequate supply of situational strength (i.e., actual levels < preferred levels) leads to worse job attitudes than an excess supply (i.e., actual levels > preferred levels). A negative facet, in contrast, is one that relates negatively to job attitudes and one for which an excess supply of situational strength leads to worse job attitudes than an inadequate supply. We therefore measured the following two situational strength facets: (1) Clarity (i.e., “the extent to which cues regarding work-related responsibilities or requirements are available and easy to understand”; Meyer et al., 2010, p. 125), a positive facet, and (2) constraints (i.e., “the extent to which an individual’s freedom of decision and action is limited by forces outside his or her control”; Meyer et al., 2010, p. 126), a negative facet.

At time 1, respondents were asked to respond with regard to clarity and constraints associated with their job in general. At

¹ In theory, employees’ perceptions regarding the organization’s view of CWB could have ranged from organizational intolerance of CWB, through organizational tolerance of CWB, all the way to active organizational encouragement of CWB. Organizational tolerance toward CWB would then have represented a weak situation, whereas *both* organizational intolerance toward CWB *and* active organizational encouragement of CWB would have represented strong situations (albeit with different levels of behavior being encouraged). However, although it was important to design the scale to accommodate this theoretical possibility, descriptive statistics revealed that respondents did not use the full range of the scale: responses to the effect that organizations actively encouraged CWB were virtually non-existent. Thus, in effect, high scores (after reverse-scoring) represented high levels of CWB-focused situational strength whereas lower scores, which were in fact mid-range rather than truly low scores, represented lower levels of CWB-focused situational strength. Future research could instead consider using response options that range from very strongly discourages to tolerates (albeit with more gradations within this range).

time 2, respondents were asked to respond with regard to clarity and constraints associated with their job during the past week. The time 1 timeframe (“in general”) was chosen to reflect protracted task-performance-focused situational strength. In contrast, the time 2 timeframe (“past week”) was chosen to reflect short-term (state-like) situational strength that would incorporate any changes to situational strength levels that may have occurred after time 1. An example of a clarity item is: “Overall (all things considered), to what extent have you been provided with specific information about your work-related responsibilities?” An example of a constraints item is: “Overall (all things considered), to what extent have you been prevented from making your own decisions?” Each facet was measured with a 7-item, 5-point scale (1 = “Not at all,” 5 = “To a very large extent”).

We did not measure the other two situational strength facets for several reasons. One reason was to keep the length of the time 1 and time 2 surveys manageable. However, there were also substantive reasons for the exclusions. The situational strength facet of consequences (i.e., the extent to which workplace decisions and/or actions have important implications; Meyer et al., 2010) is not a pure “positive” or “negative” facet because it can theoretically include both positive and negative consequences to the employee. Given that we were choosing only two facets of situational strength, we felt it was better to choose a pure positive and a pure negative facet. The facet of consistency—a positive situational strength facet—is typically defined as the congruency across various sources of situational strength (Meyer et al., 2010). Because the concept of consistency involves participants implicitly reflecting on and contrasting multiple sources of situational-strength-related information (e.g., their coworkers, immediate supervisors, top management), from a measurement standpoint clarity was a cleaner choice of a positive facet. This issue is even more important in the current dataset because, as mentioned previously, we used this dataset in one other publication that sought to “unpack” the effects of various sources of situational strength—in other words, to measure *inconsistencies* across sources. Given this, we felt that measuring the facet of consistency would have been confusing to participants.

Descriptive statistics, scale reliabilities, and intercorrelations for all measures are presented in Table 1.

Results

Tests of Focal Hypotheses

Hypothesis 1 pertained to the case where there was a match between the strength-related situational cues and the outcome domain of interest. Specifically, here the outcome of interest was CWB and the situational strength domain of interest was CWB-focused situational strength. Under these circumstances, as discussed previously, the conventional situational

strength hypothesis should hold: that is, the impact of personality on the outcome should be weaker in strong than in weak situations.

Formally, hypothesis 1 stated that the impact of personality traits on CWB would be attenuated by CWB-focused situational strength. Prior to testing this hypothesis, however, it is important to note that the assumption underlying this hypothesis was that the variability in observed levels of CWB would be lower when employees perceived high compared with low CWB-focused situational strength (Meyer et al., 2010). It is due to this restricted variance in CWB that the relationships between CWB and personality traits are attenuated.

We therefore began by testing this assumption. As can be seen in the top part of Table 2: (1) the standard deviation of CWB was indeed considerably lower (i.e., only about half as high for CWBO, and only about one-third as high for CWBI) when CWB-focused situational strength was high than when it was low, and (2) these differences were statistically significant, as indicated by Levene’s (1960) tests of equality of variances. The assumption underlying hypothesis 1 was therefore fully supported.

We therefore turn to the test of hypothesis 1 itself. We tested the hypothesis via the PROCESS macro (Hayes, 2013) in SPSS, using Template 1 (simple moderation analysis). Specifically, we conducted four simple moderation analyses: 2 outcomes (CWBO and CWBI) that matched the CWB-focused situational strength moderators $\times$ 3 personality traits (agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability). All tests of hypothesis 1, as well as all subsequent tests, used employee age and gender as statistical control variables.

Table 3 shows the results for the agreeableness-CWB, conscientiousness-CWB, and emotional stability-CWB relationships, respectively. As shown in Table 3, and as exemplified in Fig. 2, CWB-focused situational strength significantly weakened the relationship between all three personality traits, on the one hand, and both forms of CWB, on the other hand (with the unstandardized regression coefficient, B , for the interaction ranging from 0.09 to 0.21). In other words, in terms of simple slopes, the negative relationship between personality traits and CWB was weaker when CWB-focused situational strength was high (e.g., for conscientiousness and CWBO-SS, $B = -0.06$, 95% CI = $-0.20, 0.08$) than when it was low (e.g., for conscientiousness and CWBO-SS, $B = -0.37$, 95% CI = $-0.54, -0.20$)—that is, weaker when organizations were perceived to be intolerant of CWB than when they were perceived to be tolerant of CWB. Hypothesis 1 was therefore fully supported.

Hypothesis 2 pertained to the case where there was a mismatch between the strength-related situational cues and the outcome domain of interest. Specifically, here the outcome of interest was CWB whereas the situational strength domain of interest was task-performance-focused situational strength. Under these circumstances, as discussed previously, the

Table 1 Descriptive statistics, scale reliabilities, and inter-correlations

	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
1. Agreeableness	3.90	.72	(.85)													
2. Conscientiousness	4.04	.74	.61**	(.90)												
3. Emotional stability	3.69	.85	.52**	.59**	(.87)											
4. Negative affect	1.62	.69	-.43**	-.44**	-.44**	(.92)										
5. Clarity-T1	3.60	.84	.33**	.45**	.32**	-.22**	(.93)									
6. Clarity-T2	3.07	.97	.12*	.17**	.13*	.09	.42**	(.95)								
7. Constraints-T1	2.59	.91	-.32**	-.30**	-.29**	.40**	-.14**	-.01	(.95)							
8. Constraints-T2	2.28	.97	-.30**	-.33**	-.26**	.53**	-.17**	.17**	.59**	(.96)						
9. CWBO-SS	6.00	1.14	.34**	.35**	.22**	-.44**	.23**	.03	-.28**	-.38**	(.96)					
10. CWBI-SS	6.02	1.26	.33**	.28**	.19**	-.43**	.18**	.01	-.31**	-.41**	.84**	(.96)				
11. CWBO	1.96	1.06	-.35**	-.39**	-.27**	.54**	-.19**	.02	.34**	.45**	-.73**	-.67**	(.93)			
12. CWBI	1.71	1.15	-.34**	-.30**	-.19**	.52**	-.10	.11*	.35**	.48**	-.64**	-.69**	.82**	(.94)		
13. Age	33.39	9.00	.16**	.27**	.12*	-.27**	.08	-.15**	-.14**	-.20**	.14**	.18**	-.22**	-.23**	N/A	
14. Gender ^a	1.30	.46	.09	.10	-.11*	-.04	-.01	-.07	-.04	-.06	.10	.05	-.10*	-.09	.09	N/A

Note: $N = 369$. Scale reliabilities (Cronbach's alphas) are provided in parentheses on the diagonal. Variables 1–10 are mean centered prior to computing the correlations, but the means and SDs for all variables are based on the uncentered variables

M , mean; SD , standard deviation; $T1$, time 1; $T2$, time 2; $CWBO$ -SS, situational strength focusing on organizationally directed CWB; $CWBI$ -SS, situational strength focusing on interpersonally directed CWB; $CWBO$, organizationally directed CWB; $CWBI$, interpersonally directed CWB

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

Table 2 Test of assumption underlying hypotheses 1 and 2: variability in CWB as a function of situational strength

Types of situational strength	Outcome (criterion) variable					
	CWBO			CWBI		
		SD	<i>F</i> (1, 367) ^a		SD	<i>F</i> (1, 367) ^a
CWB-focused situational strength	Low (<i>N</i> = 178)	1.22	48.02*	Low (<i>N</i> = 182)	1.41	152.31*
	High (<i>N</i> = 191)	.62		High (<i>N</i> = 187)	.45	
Task performance-focused situational strength						
Clarity-T1	Low (<i>N</i> = 197)	1.08	3.20	Low (<i>N</i> = 197)	1.20	8.85*
	High (<i>N</i> = 172)	1.00		High (<i>N</i> = 172)	1.07	
Clarity-T2	Low (<i>N</i> = 185)	.80	17.00*	Low (<i>N</i> = 185)	.87	26.67*
	High (<i>N</i> = 184)	1.27		High (<i>N</i> = 184)	1.35	
Constraints-T1	Low (<i>N</i> = 184)	.61	51.96*	Low (<i>N</i> = 184)	.63	99.57*
	High (<i>N</i> = 185)	1.28		High (<i>N</i> = 185)	1.39	
Constraints-T2	Low (<i>N</i> = 198)	.63	56.58*	Low (<i>N</i> = 198)	.53	143.42*
	High (<i>N</i> = 171)	1.28		High (<i>N</i> = 171)	1.43	

Note: “Low” and “high” situational strength scores are determined on the basis of median splits. CWB-focused situational strength refers to situational strength focused on organizationally directed CWB for the outcome of CWBO and refers to situational strength focused on interpersonally directed CWB for the outcome of CWBI

CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1, time 1; T2, time 2; low, weak situation; high, strong situation

**p* < .05

^a Levene statistics for equality of variances in CWBO and CWBI across low and high situational strength groups

opposite of the conventional situational strength hypothesis should hold: namely, the impact of personality on outcomes should be stronger in strong than in weak situations. In other words, the findings should replicate the purportedly anomalous results obtained by Meyer et al. (2014).

Formally, hypothesis 2 stated that the impact of personality traits on CWB would be enhanced by task-performance-focused situational strength. Prior to testing this hypothesis, it is important to note that the assumption underlying this hypothesis was that the variability in observed levels of CWB would be *higher* when employees perceived high rather than low task-performance-focused situational strength. It is due to this greater variance in CWB that the relationships between CWB and personality traits have the potential to be enhanced.

We therefore began by testing this assumption. As can be seen in the bottom part of Table 2, for three out of the four task-performance-focused situational strength conceptualizations: (1) the standard deviation of CWB outcomes (both CWBO and CWBI) was indeed considerably higher (i.e., about 1.5 times as high for the time 2 clarity conceptualization of task-performance-focused situational strength, and more than twice as high for both the time 1 and time 2 constraints conceptualizations) when task-performance-focused situational strength was high than when it was low, and (2) these differences were statistically significant, as indicated by Levene’s (1960) tests of equality of variances. On the other hand, for the fourth task-performance-focused situational

strength conceptualization (time 1 clarity), the standard deviation of CWB outcomes was actually slightly lower (i.e., about 10% lower) when task-performance-focused situational strength was high than when it was low, and (2) these opposite (to expectations) direction differences were statistically significant (Levene, 1960) for CWBI but not CWBO. The assumption underlying hypothesis 2 was therefore mostly supported.

We therefore turn to the test of hypothesis 2 itself. Like hypothesis 1, hypothesis 2 was tested via PROCESS macro Template 1 (Hayes, 2013). Specifically, we conducted 24 simple moderation analyses: 2 outcomes (CWBO and CWBI) × 2 task-performance-focused situational strength facets (clarity and constraints) × 2 timepoints at which task-performance-focused situational strength was measured (time 1 and time 2) × 3 personality traits (agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability). Tables 4, 5, and 6 show the results for the models with agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability, respectively, as the predictor. In all 24 tests, and as exemplified in Fig. 3, the sign of the interaction term was always such that the negative relationship between personality traits and CWB was stronger when task-performance-focused situational strength was high (e.g., for conscientiousness and constraints, *B* = −0.61, 95% CI = −0.81, −0.42) than when it was low (e.g., for conscientiousness and constraints, *B* = −0.20, 95% CI = −0.40, 0.00). However, the interaction term was statistically significant in only 15 out of 24 models: 6 out of 8 models for agreeableness (the

Table 3 Test of hypothesis 1: CWB-focused situational strength as a moderator of the personality-CWB relationship

Predictor variable	Outcome (criterion) variable					
	CWBO			CWBI		
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β
Agreeableness model						
Agreeableness	-.17**	.05	-.12**	-.20**	.06	-.12**
CWB-SS	-.58**	.04	-.62**	-.52**	.04	-.57**
Agreeableness $\times$ CWB-SS	.17**	.05	.13**	.21**	.05	.16**
Age	-.01**	0	-.02**	-.01**	0	-.01*
Gender ^a	-.04	.08	-.04	-.08	.09	-.07
Main effect model R^2		.57**			.52**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.02**			.02**	
Conscientiousness model						
Conscientiousness	-.20**	.06	-.14**	-.19**	.06	-.12**
CWB-SS	-.58**	.04	-.62**	-.53**	.04	-.58**
Conscientiousness $\times$ CWB-SS	.14**	.05	.11**	.20**	.05	.16**
Age	-.01**	0	-.01*	-.01	0	-.01
Gender ^a	-.05	.08	-.04	-.1	.09	-.09
Main effect model R^2		.57**			.51**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.01**			.02**	
Emotional stability model						
Emotional stability	-.18**	.05	-.14**	-.11*	.05	-.08*
CWB-SS	-.59**	.04	-.64**	-.57**	.04	-.63**
Emotional stability $\times$ CWB-SS	.15**	.05	.14**	.09*	.05	.08*
Age	-.01**	0	-.01**	-.01*	0	-.01*
Gender ^a	-.08	.09	-.08	-.13	.09	-.11
Main effect model R^2		.57**			.49**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.01**			.01**	

Note: Age and gender are control variables. For the model with CWBO as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBO-focused situational strength; for the model with CWBI as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBI-focused Situational Strength

CWB-SS, CWB-focused situational strength; CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; s.e., standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

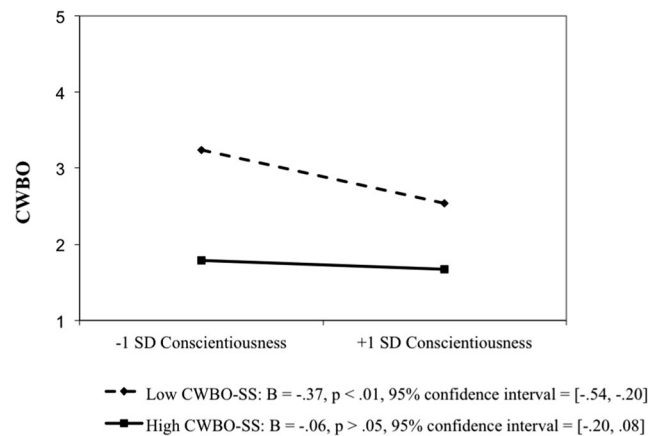
exception being the two models involving time 1 clarity), all 8 models for conscientiousness, and only 1 out of 8 models for emotional stability (with all models *except* the one involving time 2 clarity yielding nonsignificant results). Hypothesis 2 was, therefore, mostly supported in the case of agreeableness, fully supported in the case of conscientiousness, and unsupported in the case of emotional stability.

Hypotheses 3 and 4 were also tested via PROCESS macro in SPSS (Hayes, 2013). We used Template 21 (dual-stage moderated mediation) to analyze 24 models: 2 outcomes (CWBO and CWBI) that matched the CWB-focused situational strength moderator $\times$ 2 task-performance-focused situational strength facets (clarity and constraints) $\times$ 2 timepoints

at which task-performance-focused situational strength was measured (time 1 and time 2) $\times$ 3 personality traits (agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability). Regression results for the overall model (Fig. 1) are provided in Tables 7, 8, and 9 for agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability, respectively, as the predictor.

Hypothesis 3 stated that the moderating (specifically, strengthening) effect of task-performance-focused situational strength on the relationship between personality traits and CWB would itself be mediated by negative affect. As shown in Tables 7, 8, and 9, the sign of the first-stage interaction term was always such that the negative relationship between personality traits and negative affect was stronger when task-performance-

Fig. 2 Plot of an interaction between conscientiousness and counterproductive-work-behavior-focused (and organizationally directed) situational strength in the prediction of organizationally directed counterproductive work behavior (test of hypothesis 1). SD, standard deviation; CWBO, organizationally directed counterproductive work behavior; CWBO-SS, CWB-focused (and organizationally directed) situational strength



focused situational strength was high. However, the first-stage interaction term was statistically significant in only 7 out of 12 models: 3 out of 4 models for agreeableness (the exception being the model involving time 1 clarity), 3 out of 4 models for conscientiousness (the exception again being the model involving time 1 clarity), and 1 out of 4 models for emotional stability (with all models *except* the one involving time 2 clarity yielding non-significant results). In addition, negative affect significantly predicted CWBO and CWBI in all 24 models. Hypothesis 3 was, therefore, mostly supported in the case of agreeableness and conscientiousness, but unsupported in the case of emotional stability.

Hypothesis 4 stated that the second-stage relationship, in the moderated mediation model originally proposed in hypothesis 3, would be moderated (specifically, weakened) by CWB-focused situational strength (see Fig. 1). As shown in Tables 7, 8, and 9, the sign of the second-stage interaction term was always (i.e., in all 24 models) such that the negative relationship between negative affect and CWB (either CWBO or CWBI) was stronger when CWB-focused situational strength was high. Moreover, the second-stage interaction term was statistically significant in all 24 models. Further, although space limitations preclude a full tabulation of these results, we note briefly that, for both low and high levels of the first-stage moderator (task-performance-focused situational strength), the indirect effect of the predictor on the outcome (via the mediator, negative affect) was significantly negative when the second-stage moderator (CWB-focused situational strength) was low but was nonsignificant when it was high. This pattern was consistent across all 24 models. Hypothesis 4 was therefore fully supported.

Supplementary Analyses

As reported in the “Participants and Procedures” subsection of the “Method” section, our sample included employees from the USA and India. Although cross-cultural influences are not a

primary emphasis of the current paper, we conducted supplementary (and exploratory) analyses to examine whether the focal conclusions hold in both countries. Specifically, we used PROCESS macro Template 48 (Hayes, 2013) to examine whether the two-way first- and second-stage interactions that are the focus of the study are further qualified—in three-way interactions—by country (USA vs. India). Results indicated that no first-stage three-way interactions (personality $\times$ task-performance-focused situational strength $\times$ country) were statistically significant (average β across the 12 models = $-.02$). This suggests that the two-way (personality $\times$ task-performance-focused situational strength) first-stage interaction held equally in both the USA and India. Results additionally indicated that, across models, the second-stage three-way interactions (NA $\times$ CWB-focused situational strength $\times$ country) were always statistically significant and in the same direction (average β for NA $\times$ CWBO-SS $\times$ country = $.14$ and average β for NA $\times$ CWBI-SS $\times$ country = $.18$), such that the two-way (NA $\times$ CWB-focused situational strength) second-stage interaction was stronger for Indian respondents than for the US respondents. Despite this significant moderating effect of country, however, the focal two-way second-stage interaction always remained statistically significant (average β for NA $\times$ CWBO-SS = $-.11$ and average β for NA $\times$ CWBI-SS = $-.15$) in the presence of the three-way interaction. This suggests that the overall model held for both the US and Indian respondents, but that it held even more strongly for the Indian respondents.

Discussion

Summary of Findings

According to the primary situational strength prediction, personality predicts outcomes such as job performance more strongly in weak than in strong situations. The current paper

Table 4 Test of hypothesis 2: task-performance-focused situational strength as a moderator of the agreeableness-CWB relationship

Predictor variable	Outcome (criterion) variable					
	CWBO			CWBI		
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β
Clarity-T1 model						
Agreeableness	– .43**	.08	– .29**	– .48**	.08	– .30**
Clarity-T1	– .10	.07	– .08	.01	.07	.01
Agreeableness $\times$ clarity-T1	– .04	.09	– .02	– .11	.09	– .06
Age	– .02**	.01	– .02**	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .15	.11	– .14	– .13	.12	– .11
Main effect model R^2		.16**			.15**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		0			0	
Clarity-T2 model						
Agreeableness	– .48**	.07	– .32**	– .52**	.08	– .32**
Clarity-T2	.05	.05	.05	.18**	.06	.15**
Agreeableness $\times$ clarity-T2	– .21**	.07	– .14**	– .26**	.08	– .15**
Age	– .02**	.01	– .02**	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .14	.11	– .13	– .10	.12	– .08
Main effect model R^2		.17**			.18**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.02**			.02**	
Constraints-T1 model						
Agreeableness	– .38**	.07	– .25**	– .38**	.08	– .24**
Constraints-T1	.29**	.06	.25**	.33**	.06	.26**
Agreeableness $\times$ constraints-T1	– .19*	.08	– .11*	– .26**	.08	– .14**
Age	– .02**	.01	– .01**	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .12	.11	– .12	– .10	.12	– .08
Main effect model R^2		.22**			.22**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.01*			.02**	
Constraints-T2 model						
Agreeableness	– .35**	.07	– .24**	– .35**	.07	– .22**
Constraints-T2	.38**	.05	.34**	.44**	.05	.37**
Agreeableness $\times$ constraints-T2	– .22**	.07	– .14**	– .34**	.07	– .21**
Age	– .01*	0	– .01*	– .01*	.01	– .01*
Gender ^a	– .12	.1	– .12	– .10	.11	– .08
Main effect model R^2		.28**			.32**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.02**			.04**	

Note: Age and gender are control variables

CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1 time 1; T2, time 2; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; *s.e.*, standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

serves as a cautionary tale by suggesting that this primary situational strength prediction holds only when situational strength cues match the outcome domain (i.e., performance criterion) of interest. When predicting CWB, therefore, the primary prediction holds consistently—that is, across the three personality traits of agreeableness, conscientiousness, and

emotional stability—for a CWB-focused form of situational strength, which we conceptualized in terms of the organization's extent of intolerance of CWB.

More interesting, however, is what happens when there is a mismatch between the situational strength cues that operate and the outcome of interest: for instance, when using task-

Table 5 Test of hypothesis 2: task-performance-focused situational strength as a moderator of the conscientiousness-CWB relationship

Predictor variable	Outcome (criterion) variable					
	CWBO			CWBI		
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β
Clarity-T1 model						
Conscientiousness	– .51**	.08	– .35**	– .46**	.09	– .29**
Clarity-T1	– .02	.07	– .01	.06	.08	.05
Conscientiousness $\times$ clarity-T1	– .21*	.09	– .12*	– .22*	.1	– .12*
Age	– .01*	.01	– .01*	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .15	.11	– .14	– .13	.12	– .12
Main effect model R^2		.18**			.13**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.01*			.01*	
Clarity-T2 model						
Conscientiousness	– .56**	.07	– .39**	– .50**	.08	– .32**
Clarity-T2	.12*	.05	– .11*	.23**	.06	.20**
Conscientiousness $\times$ clarity-T2	– .32**	.07	– .21**	– .36**	.08	– .22**
Age	– .01*	.01	– .01*	– .01*	.01	– .01*
Gender ^a	– .10	.11	– .09	– .07	.12	– .06
Main effect model R^2		.21**			.18**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.04**			.05**	
Constraints-T1 model						
Conscientiousness	– .41**	.07	– .28**	– .29**	.08	– .18**
Constraints-T1	.30**	.06	.25**	.37**	.06	.29**
Conscientiousness $\times$ constraints-T1	– .23**	.08	– .14**	– .28**	.08	– .16**
Age	– .01*	.01	– .01*	– .02**	.01	– .01*
Gender ^a	– .15	.11	– .14	– .14	.12	– .12
Main effect model (R^2)		.24**			.21**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.02**			.03**	
Constraints-T2 model						
Conscientiousness	– .36**	.07	– .25**	– .23**	.08	– .15**
Constraints-T2	.38**	.05	.35**	.48**	.06	.40**
Conscientiousness $\times$ constraints-T2	– .17*	.07	– .12*	– .31**	.08	– .18**
Age	– .01	.01	– .01	– .01	.01	– .01
Gender ^a	– .13	.1	– .12	– .14	.11	– .11
Main effect model R^2		.28**			.21**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.01*			.02**	

Note: Age and gender are control variables

CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1, time 1; T2, time 2; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; s.e., standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

performance-focused situational strength to predict CWB. We contended that, due to a behavioral substitution or displacement effect, the *opposite* of the primary situational strength prediction would hold: namely, that personality would actually

predict outcomes more strongly in strong than weak situations. Stated differently, the pattern of results we predicted was precisely the “anomalous” pattern observed by Meyer et al. (2014). Results revealed strong support for this contention in

Table 6 Test of hypothesis 2: task-performance-focused situational strength as a moderator of the emotional stability-CWB relationship

Predictor variable	Outcome (criterion) variable					
	CWBO			CWBI		
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β
Clarity-T1 model						
Emotional stability	– .29**	.06	– .23**	– .23**	.07	– .17**
Clarity-T1	– .13	.06	– .10	– .04	.07	– .03
Emotional stability $\times$ clarity-T1	– .06	.07	– .04	– .10	.08	– .06
Age	– .02**	.01	– .02**	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .27*	.11	– .25*	– .23	.13	– .20
Main effect model R^2		.13**			.09**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		0			0	
Clarity-T2 model						
Emotional stability	– .34**	.06	– .27**	– .27**	.07	– .20**
Clarity-T2	.03	.05	.03	.15*	.06	.13*
Emotional stability $\times$ clarity-T2	– .12	.06	– .09	– .18**	.07	– .13**
Age	– .02**	.01	– .02**	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .26*	.11	– .24*	– .20	.12	– .18
Main effect model R^2		.17**			.12**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		.02**			.02**	
Constraints-T1 model						
Emotional stability	– .23**	.06	– .19**	– .13	.07	– .09
Constraints-T1	.30**	.06	.26**	.37**	.06	.29**
Emotional stability $\times$ constraints-T1	– .07	.06	– .05	– .08	.07	– .05
Age	– .02**	.01	– .02**	– .02**	.01	– .02**
Gender ^a	– .23*	.11	– .22*	– .18	.12	– .16
Main effect model R^2		.18**			.17**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		0			0	
Constraints-T2 model						
Emotional stability	– .22**	.06	– .17**	– .11	.06	– .08
Constraints-T2	.40**	.05	.37**	.49**	.06	.42**
Emotional stability $\times$ constraints-T2	– .07	.06	– .06	– .11	.06	– .08
Age	– .01*	0	– .01*	– .02**	.01	– .01**
Gender ^a	– .20	.11	– .19	– .14	.11	– .12
Main effect model R^2		.25**			.26**	
ΔR^2 for interaction		0			.01	

Note: Age and gender are control variables

CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1, time 1; T2, time 2; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; s.e., standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

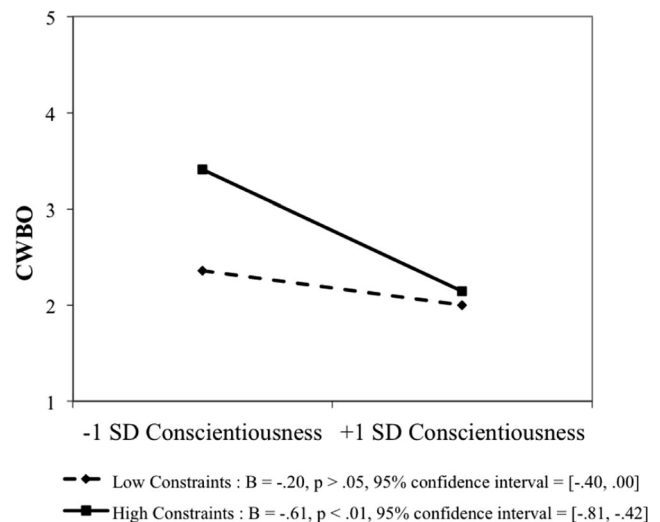
* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

the case of agreeableness and conscientiousness—the two personality traits studied by Meyer et al. (2014)—thereby replicating the results obtained by those authors, but little support in the case of a third personality trait, emotional stability.

We moreover predicted that blocking one “outlet” for low performance (e.g., low task performance) results in negative affect on the part of employees inclined toward such behavior—and that this negative affect results in a displacement toward another, more available form of low performance

Fig. 3 Plot of an interaction between conscientiousness and task-performance-focused situational strength (specifically, the constraints facet) in the prediction of organizationally directed counterproductive work behavior (test of hypothesis 2). SD, standard deviation; CWBO, organizationally directed counterproductive work behavior; constraints, the constraints facet of task-performance-focused situational strength



(e.g., CWB). We once again found strong support for this hypothesis in the case of agreeableness and conscientiousness, but little support in the case of emotional stability.

Finally, we predicted that this exacerbated dispositional tendency to engage in the second form of low performance can itself only be blocked by the presence of a strong situation focused on that second form of low performance. As a result, researchers should pay close attention to the extent to which their conceptualization of situational strength is a match for their behavior/performance outcome of interest. We found consistently strong support for this hypothesis across all three personality traits (conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability).

In general, then, we found much stronger support for the hypotheses as they pertained to agreeableness and conscientiousness (the two traits studied by Meyer et al., 2014) than as they pertained to emotional stability. These results appear to reinforce our previously stated contention (see the “Method” section) that situational strength research will be most fruitful with regard to personality traits that exhibit the highest-magnitude “baseline” (i.e., without considering situational strength) relationships with job performance criteria. In the case of CWB, agreeableness and conscientiousness exhibit the highest-magnitude relationships (see Table 1 in the current paper as well as Berry et al.’s, 2007, meta-analysis). Moreover, although not just agreeableness and conscientiousness but also emotional stability are commonly viewed as providing the basis for dispositional “integrity”—a compound trait frequently used to predict CWB in applied personnel selection settings—research suggests that integrity is composed more heavily of conscientiousness and agreeableness than of emotional stability (Marcus et al., 2006; see also Catano et al., 2018).

An alternative possibility is that emotional instability almost by definition implies fluctuation between high and low levels of negative affect. In other words, perhaps high levels of experienced negative affect on many occasions are simply to be expected of people scoring low on emotional stability (relative to people scoring low on conscientiousness or agreeableness). Based on our results, we might speculate that this tendency for emotional instability to result in negative affect is so fundamental that it is not appreciably influenced by task-performance-focused situational strength (despite the fact that the subsequent “translation” of that negative affect into CWB is indeed influenced by CWB-focused situational strength even for people exhibiting emotional instability). In summary, both of the above explanations suggest that, although we included emotional stability to more fully reflect the “integrity” perspective, the conceptual case for expecting our predictions to be supported with regard to emotional stability (vs. conscientiousness and agreeableness) was arguably less solid.

Finally, although country-level differences were not a primary focus of our study, we did investigate such differences via supplementary analyses. We found that our hypothesized second-stage interaction (i.e., between negative affect and CWB-focused situational strength) was supported in the US subsample and was supported even more strongly in the Indian subsample. More generally, this raises the question of what role(s) societal level—that is, country or culture level—effects related to situational strength may place in workplace-level situational strength studies. In this regard, it is relevant to note that cross-cultural researchers have conceptualized

Table 7 Test of hypotheses 3 and 4: regression results for overall model with agreeableness as predictor

Predictor variable	Mediator variable				Outcome (criterion) variable							
	NA				CWBO				CWBI			
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²
				.24**				.61**				.58**
Clarity-T1 model												
Agreeableness	−.35**	.05	−.37**		−.08	.05	−.06		−.11	.06	−.07	
Clarity-T1	−.07	.04	−.08		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Agreeableness × clarity-T1	−.06	.05	−.05		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.27**	.06	.17**		.24**	.07	.14**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.50**	.04	−.53**		−.43**	.04	−.48**	
NA × CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.15**	.03	−.11**		−.21**	.03	−.16**	
Age	−.01**	0	−.02**		−.01	0	−.01		−.01	0	−.01	
Gender ^a	.01	.07	.02		−.07	.08	−.06		−.1	.08	−.09	
				.28**				.61**				.58**
Clarity-T2 model												
Agreeableness	−.40**	.04	−.42**		−.08	.05	−.06		−.11	.06	−.07	
Clarity-T2	.10**	.03	.14**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Agreeableness × clarity-T2	−.20**	.05	−.20**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.27**	.06	.17**		.24**	.07	.14**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.50**	.04	−.53**		−.43**	.04	−.48**	
NA × CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.15**	.03	−.11**		−.21**	.03	−.16**	
Age	−.01**	0	−.02**		−.01	0	−.01		−.01	0	−.01	
Gender ^a	.03	.07	.05		−.07	.08	−.06		−.1	.08	−.09	
				.31**				.61**				.58**
Constraints-T1 model												
Agreeableness	−.31**	.04	−.32**		−.08	.05	−.06		−.11	.06	−.07	
Constraints-T1	.22**	.04	.28**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Agreeableness × constraints-T1	−.10*	.05	−.09*		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.27**	.06	.17**		.24**	.07	.14**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.50**	.04	−.53**		−.43**	.04	−.48**	
NA × CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.15**	.03	−.11**		−.21**	.03	−.16**	
Age	−.01**	0	−.02**		−.01	0	−.01		−.01	0	−.01	
Gender ^a	.03	.07	.05		−.07	.08	−.06		−.1	.08	−.09	
				.40**				.61**				.58**
Constraints-T2 model												
Agreeableness	−.29**	.04	−.30**		−.08	.05	−.06		−.11	.06	−.07	
Constraints-T2	.28**	.03	.40**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Agreeableness × constraints-T2	−.14**	.04	−.15**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.27**	.06	.17**		.24**	.07	.14**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.50**	.04	−.53**		−.43**	.04	−.48**	
NA × CWB-SS	—	—	—		−.15**	.03	−.11**		−.21**	.03	−.16**	
Age	−.01**	0	−.02**		−.01	0	−.01		−.01	0	−.01	
Gender ^a	.04	.06	.05		−.07	.08	−.06		−.1	.08	−.09	

Note: For the models with CWBO as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBO-focused situational strength; for the models with CWBI as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBI-focused situational strength. Age and gender are control variables

CWB-SS, CWB-focused situational strength; NA, negative affect; CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1, time 1; T2, time 2; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; *s.e.*, standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

societal-level situational strength versus weakness as “cultural tightness versus looseness” (i.e., “the strength of social norms and sanctioning within a society”; Gelfand, Nishii, & Raver, 2006, p. 1225; see also Gelfand & Lun, 2013). In a multilevel design that involves work organizations nested within

countries, country-level situational strength (i.e., cultural tightness-looseness) may for instance serve as an upper-level antecedent to workplace situational strength and/or as a cross-level moderator of lower-level relationships between situational strength and employee performance (see Gelfand

et al.'s, 2006, conceptual multilevel model). Of the two countries we studied, India does have a somewhat tighter culture than the USA, but neither country has a particularly tight or a particularly loose culture (as per the country-level scores provided by Uz, 2015). Moreover, with only two countries, it is hard to unconfound the effects of cultural tightness-looseness from those of other cultural dimensions (e.g., individualism-collectivism). Therefore, a proper test of the workplace effects of cultural tightness-looseness would: (1) involve a variety of countries (with a variety of workplaces nested within each country) that span the range of country-level tightness-looseness scores, and (2) control for country-level scores on other cultural dimensions. This is admittedly a tall order, but an acceptable approximation might involve a study consisting of two small groups of countries—for example, two groups of three countries each—chosen so that they collectively represent an “extreme groups” design with regard to cultural tightness-looseness (but not with regard to other cultural dimensions).

Limitations

The current paper's findings should be interpreted in light of its methodological limitations. One potential limitation involves the exclusive use of self-report measures, thereby raising the possibility of common-method variance (specifically, same-source bias) and therefore inflated relationships. However, for multiple reasons we believe that our use of self-report measures is quite defensible.

With regard to the outcome variable (CWB), as noted in the “Method” section (see also Berry et al., 2012), self-reports are a well-established source of ratings and are considered a viable and perhaps even superior alternative to other reports. Turning now to situational strength, we note first of all that perceptions (generated via self-report) of situational forces are considered not only the situational operationalizations most proximal to behavior (Mischel, Shoda, & Mendoza-Denton, 2002) but also “the most relevant level of situational analysis for theory building and research” (Hatrup & Jackson, 1996, p. 512). Second, our use of perceptual (hence, self-report) measures of situational strength is consistent with previous research. For instance, Meyer et al. (2014) used self-report measures of task-performance-focused situational strength, and Yang et al.'s (2014) meta-analysis involved perceptual, self-report measures of workplace mistreatment climate, which is definitionally and operationally very similar to our CWBI-focused situational strength. Third, Meyer et al. (2014) demonstrated that their perceptual measure of situational strength (used in slightly adapted form in the present study) is responsive to even subtle changes in objective situational strength. Fourth, when aggregated to the occupation level, Meyer et al.'s (2014) perceptual measure of situational strength exhibits convergence with occupation-level

situational strength scores generated via the Occupational Information Network (O*NET; <https://www.onetonline.org/>).² Fifth, several studies discussing perceptual/psychological climates for interpersonal forms of CWB (e.g., violence prevention climate: Chang, Eatough, Spector, & Kessler, 2012; workplace civility climate: Ottnot, 2010)—that is, essentially, subsets of our conceptualization of CWBI-focused situational strength—have aggregated up from the individual employee level to the unit level and, in the process, have demonstrated adequate interrater agreement.

Furthermore, separating measures of predictors and criteria temporally (by collecting data in two waves), as we did, reduces common-method variance in the case of a single rater (Podsakoff et al., 2003). Finally, in any case, interaction effects—which were the sole or partial focus of each of our hypotheses—cannot be viewed as artifacts of common-method variance (Evans, 1985; Siemsen, Roth, & Oliveira, 2010).

These multiple lines of evidence notwithstanding, we acknowledge that the sole reliance on self-report data at the level of the individual employee constitutes a limitation of the current study. Future research should therefore replicate our findings using: (1) other reports of CWB or objective measures of CWB (e.g., based on personnel records and electronic performance monitoring), (2) other reports of personality, and/or (3) measures of task-performance-focused and CWB-focused situational strength at levels of analysis other than the individual employee (e.g., the occupation for task-performance-focused situational strength and the organization for CWB-focused situational strength).

Another limitation of the current study is that, although the current research design employed two timepoints, the mediator (negative affect) and outcomes (CWBO and

² We are grateful to Rustin D. Meyer for providing us with an unpublished dataset. The dataset in question contained the Meyer et al. (2014) perceptual four-facet (clarity, consistency, constraints, and consequences) measure of task-performance-focused situational strength. The dataset also contained respondents' own judgments regarding the O*NET occupation that best fit their current job—thereby permitting us to generate occupation-level task-performance-focused situational strength scores using Meyer et al.'s (2009) two-facet (constraints and consequences) O*NET-based measure of situational strength. The current study measured clarity and constraints, the convergence of the latter of which can be assessed via the unpublished dataset. In the unpublished dataset, we were able to find 25 occupations that were each associated with 10 or more respondents (total usable $n = 505$). We aggregated the Meyer et al. (2014) constraints scores up to the occupation level. Interrater agreement was strong (on the basis of LeBreton & Senter's, 2008, rules of thumb): median $r_{wg(j)} = 0.77$, using a uniform error variance distribution. For the 25 occupations, reliabilities (Cronbach's alphas) were 0.95 for the Meyer et al. (2014) perceptual measure of constraints and 0.62 for the Meyer et al. (2009) O*NET measure of constraints. The observed correlation between scores on the two constraints measures across these 25 occupations was 0.35, $p < .10$. The correlation corrected for unreliability in both measures was 0.46, $p < .05$. Given the differences in the nature of the items used to measure constraints across the two measures, this constitutes an appreciable level of convergence.

Table 8 Test of hypotheses 3 and 4: regression results for overall model with conscientiousness as predictor

Predictor variable	Mediator variable				Outcome (criterion) variable							
	NA				CWBO				CWBI			
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²
				.23**				.62**				.58**
Clarity-T1 model												
Conscientiousness	-.37**	.05	-.40**		-.14*	.05	-.09*		-.08	.06	-.05	
Clarity-T1	-.02	.04	-.02		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Conscientiousness $\times$ clarity-T1	-.11	.06	-.10		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.06	.16**		.25**	.07	.15**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.49**	.04	-.52**		-.44**	.04	-.48**	
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.12**		-.21**	.03	-.16**	
Age	-.01**	0	-.02**		0	0	0		0	0	0	
Gender ^a	.01	.07	.02		-.06	.07	-.06		-.1	.09	-.09	
				.28**				.62**				.58**
Clarity-T2 model												
Conscientiousness	-.43**	.04	-.46**		-.14*	.05	-.09*		-.08	.06	-.05	
Clarity-T2	.14**	.03	.20**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Conscientiousness $\times$ clarity-T2	-.21**	.04	-.22**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.06	.16**		.25**	.07	.15**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.49**	.04	-.52**		-.44**	.04	-.48**	
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.12**		-.21**	.03	-.16**	
Age	-.01**	0	-.01**		0	0	0		0	0	0	
Gender ^a	.05	.07	.08		-.06	.07	-.06		-.1	.09	-.09	
				.31**				.62**				.58**
Constraints-T1 model												
Conscientiousness	-.30**	.04	-.32**		-.14*	.05	-.09*		-.08	.06	-.05	
Constraints-T1	.23**	.03	.30**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Conscientiousness $\times$ constraints-T1	-.12**	.05	-.12**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.06	.16**		.25**	.07	.15**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.49**	.04	-.52**		-.44**	.04	-.48**	
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.12**		-.21**	.03	-.16**	
Age	-.01**	0	-.02**		0	0	0		0	0	0	
Gender ^a	.02	.07	.03		-.06	.07	-.06		-.1	.09	-.09	
				.38**				.62**				.58**
Constraints-T2 model												
Conscientiousness	-.26**	.04	-.28**		-.14*	.05	-.09*		-.08	.06	-.05	
Constraints-T2	.29**	.03	.41**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
Conscientiousness $\times$ constraints-T2	-.12**	.04	-.13**		—	—	—		—	—	—	
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.06	.16**		.25**	.07	.15**	
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.49**	.04	-.52**		-.44**	.04	-.48**	
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.12**		-.21**	.03	-.16**	
Age	-.01*	0	-.01*		0	0	0		0	0	0	
Gender ^a	.03	.06	.04		-.06	.07	-.06		-.10	.09	-.09	

Note: For the models with CWBO as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBO-focused situational strength; for the models with CWBI as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBI-focused situational strength. Age and gender are control variables

CWB-SS, CWB-focused situational strength; NA, negative affect; CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1, time 1; T2, time 2; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; s.e., standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

CWBI) were not separated temporally. Future research could instead use a three-timepoint cross-lagged design, so as to yield stronger causal inferences.

Avenues for Future Research

Given that the current paper provides an extension of situational strength theory, and only the first empirical test thereof,

several avenues for future research are readily apparent. One such avenue is straightforward. Researchers should properly map the job performance construct space (Austin & Villanova, 1992) so that they can identify all the outcome domains of interest. Subsequently, researchers should develop conceptualizations (and corresponding measures) of situational strength associated with each of the important outcome domains. In other words, the conceptual (and empirical)

Table 9 Test of hypotheses 3 and 4: regression results for overall model with emotional stability as predictor

Predictor variable	Mediator variable				Outcome (criterion) variable									
	NA				CWBO				CWBI					
	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²	<i>B</i>	s.e.	β	<i>R</i> ²		
				.25**					.62**					.58**
Clarity-T1 model														
Emotional stability	-.32**	.04	-.40**		-.08	.05	-.07		-.01	.05	0			
Clarity-T1	-.06	.04	-.07		—	—	—		—	—	—			
Emotional stability $\times$ clarity-T1	-.06	.04	-.06		—	—	—		—	—	—			
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.07	.16**		.29**	.08	.17**			
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.50**	.04	-.54**		-.45**	.04	-.49**			
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.11**		-.21**	.03	-.15**			
Age	-.02**	0	-.02**		-.01	0	-.01		-.01	0	0			
Gender ^a	-.10	.07	-.14		-.09	.08	-.09		-.11	.09	-.10			
				.28**					.62**					.58**
Clarity-T2 model														
Emotional stability	-.36**	.04	-.44**		-.08	.05	-.07		-.01	.05	0			
Clarity-T2	.09**	.03	.13**		—	—	—		—	—	—			
Emotional stability $\times$ clarity-T2	-.11**	.04	-.13**		—	—	—		—	—	—			
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.07	.16**		.29**	.08	.17**			
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.50**	.04	-.54**		-.45**	.04	-.49**			
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.11**		-.21**	.03	-.15**			
Age	-.01**	0	-.02**		-.01	0	-.01		-.01	0	0			
Gender ^a	-.08	.07	-.12		-.09	.08	-.09		-.11	.09	-.10			
				.31**					.62**					.58**
Constraints-T1 model														
Emotional stability	-.28**	.04	-.34**		-.08	.05	-.07		-.01	.05	0			
Constraints-T1	.21**	.03	.28**		—	—	—		—	—	—			
Emotional stability $\times$ constraints-T1	-.02	.04	-.03		—	—	—		—	—	—			
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.07	.16**		.29**	.08	.17**			
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.50**	.04	-.54**		-.45**	.04	-.49**			
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.11**		-.21**	.03	-.15**			
Age	-.01**	0	-.02**		-.01	0	-.01		-.01	0	0			
Gender ^a	-.07	.07	-.10		-.09	.08	-.09		-.11	.09	-.10			
				.40**					.62**					.58**
Constraints-T2 model														
Emotional stability	-.26**	.03	-.32**		-.08	.05	-.07		-.01	.05	0			
Constraints-T2	.29**	.03	.40**		—	—	—		—	—	—			
Emotional stability $\times$ constraints-T2	-.03	.03	-.04		—	—	—		—	—	—			
NA	—	—	—		.25**	.07	.16**		.29**	.08	.17**			
CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.50**	.04	-.54**		-.45**	.04	-.49**			
NA $\times$ CWB-SS	—	—	—		-.16**	.03	-.11**		-.21**	.03	-.15**			
Age	-.01**	0	-.02**		-.01	0	-.01		-.01	0	0			
Gender ^a	-.05	.06	-.07		-.09	.08	-.09		-.11	.09	-.10			

Note: For the models with CWBO as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBO-focused situational strength; for the models with CWBI as the outcome, CWB-SS refers to CWBI-focused situational strength. Age and gender are control variables

CWB-SS, CWB-focused situational strength; NA, negative affect; CWBO, organizationally directed CWB; CWBI, interpersonally directed CWB; T1, time 1; T2, time 2; *B*, unstandardized regression coefficient; s.e., standard error; β , standardized regression coefficient

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

^a Male = 1; female = 2

structure of situational strength should arguably mirror that of job performance.

Second, future research could test essentially the “opposite” of the current conceptual model. We found (as did Meyer et al., 2014) that task-performance-focused situational strength amplifies rather than attenuates the impact of personality on CWB. However, our conceptual rationale (viz., displacement from one form of low performance to another as a result of a strong situation applied to the first form of low

performance) suggests, equally, that CWB-focused situational strength should amplify rather than attenuate the impact of personality on task performance. Future research could be designed to test this idea by using task performance as an outcome variable and by reversing the order of the two moderator variables. Unlike CWB, however, task performance is not appropriately measured via self-reports. Future research testing this idea could therefore use other reports (e.g., supervisor or coworker reports) of task performance or else

objective measures of results (i.e., what Campbell, 1990, calls “effectiveness”).

Third, future research could test an extension of the current conceptual model. If strong situations are applied simultaneously to *all* the major domains of job performance (e.g., task performance, CWB, and other important forms of job performance), it may be that dispositional tendencies toward low performance will be displaced outside the workplace altogether—say to the family domain, where employees may kick their dog, behave badly with their domestic partner, and/or neglect to do necessary housework.

A fourth area for future research involves a more precise examination of the forms of negative affect involved in the behavioral displacement process we have outlined. It seems unlikely that the displacement process is driven by fear, guilt, or shame; however, that still leaves anger and distress, and perhaps even contempt and disgust, as plausible candidates (using Izard’s, 1977, categorization of basic negative emotions). On the contrary, however, fear may be implicated in an employee’s decision to avoid engaging in a particular negative behavior in a strong situation indicating the organization’s intolerance for such behavior. Therefore, some discrete negative emotions (e.g., anger) might be associated primarily with *reactance* to strong situations whereas others (e.g., fear) might be associated primarily with *adherence* to strong situations. Research in this area would influence not just the situational strength literature but the behavioral displacement literature more generally: for instance, literature on the compensatory forms of withdrawal model, displaced aggression, and reactance.

Fifth, future research could look at: (1) additional facets of task-performance-focused situational strength (e.g., consistency, consequences; Meyer et al., 2010, 2014) that we, for reasons described previously, could not examine in the current paper, (2) faceted conceptualizations of CWB-focused situational strength (e.g., conceptualizations based on the clarity and consistency of CWB-related informational cues as well as the constraints on and consequences for enacting CWB—i.e., paralleling the structure of task-performance-focused situational strength proposed by Meyer et al., 2010, 2014), (3) the sources of both task-performance-focused and CWB-focused situational strength (e.g., coworkers, immediate supervisor, top management; Alaybek et al., 2017), and (4) facet-by-source interactions.

Practical Implications

The current findings suggest the importance of situational strength focused not just on deterring low task performance but also on deterring CWB. Extrapolating from research on organizational climates (Zohar, 1980; Zohar & Hofmann, 2012), human resources (HR) practitioners aiming to develop strong situations that deter CWB would do well to ensure top management buy-in. Such buy-in facilitates the development of

this type of strong situation as a priority relative to other, potentially competing, objectives such as maximizing employee autonomy. HR practitioners would also do well to understand that HR policies are likely to influence CWB-focused situational strength, but in multiple ways. For instance, telework affords ambiguity (i.e., creates a generally weak situation) that can facilitate CWB (e.g., Dalal & Meyer, 2012). At a more fine-grained level, however, telework especially creates opportunities for specific types of CWB (e.g., lying about an illness or about home appliance repair needs in order to justify excessive teleworking) while reducing opportunities for engaging in other types of CWB (e.g., stealing from and getting into fistfights with coworkers are less feasible while teleworking; Holland, Simpson, Dalal, & Vega, 2016).

The current findings moreover provide a cautionary tale, suggesting that strong situations will not always attenuate the impact of personality on job performance. In organizational settings, strong situations are often applied with the aim of reducing poor performance among employees dispositionally inclined toward poor performance (Dalal & Meyer, 2012). However, if they are not carefully enacted, strong situations may in fact lead to unintended negative consequences. That is, rather than reducing poor performance, strong situations may simply displace poor performance to a different “outlet.” Thus, other forms of poor performance may actually be amplified. The current research therefore suggests the importance of adopting a holistic approach to job performance, which in practice will result in blocking *all* outlets for employee poor performance by imposing strong situations across every outlet. As alluded to previously, the forms of situational strength necessary to block outlets for poor job performance are likely to follow directly from the job performance criteria considered important by the organization. The current results, in other words, provide additional support to the admonishment (see Austin & Villanova, 1992) that practitioners (and researchers) do not pay sufficient attention to the job performance criterion space.

Moreover, because identifying and blocking every outlet for poor performance may be challenging to achieve in practice, the current research also indirectly suggests the importance of other approaches. One such approach would emphasize employee selection: specifically, the selection of employees who are conscientious and agreeable. For instance, employees with high scores on conscientiousness will attempt to avoid low task performance *and* high CWB. Importantly, these employees will avoid multiple forms of low performance of their own volition, not because of strong situations imposed on them. A second approach would facilitate alternative responses to negative affect. For instance, compared to engaging in CWB, trying to improve conditions by voicing concerns to supervisors or other organizational authorities is a more constructive response to negative affect (Hirschman, 1970). Instead of, or in addition to, creating strong situations aimed at deterring CWB, organizations can create strong situations aimed at facilitating voice.

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